

Jeans: From Genoa To James Dean [B1]

Dal porto della Genova medievale a capo presente in qualsiasi armadio: il tutto grazie a un adattamento fonetico, Marlon Brando e James Dean.



Everything begins with the great textile tradition of Genoa on the northwestern coast of Italy. As early as the Middle Ages, the people of Genoa produced a

strong [fabric](#) made of [cotton](#) imported from the eastern Mediterranean. It was used to make clothes for [sailors](#) and port workers, as well as sacks, [sails](#) and covers for [goods](#). The first ambassadors of this [garment](#) were [therefore](#) Genoese [sailors](#) who wore it on their journeys to Mediterranean ports in France and Spain, to England and around the world.

A DURABLE GARMENT

At that time, it was common for imported [goods](#) to take their name from the place they came from. For this reason, the French identified this [fabric](#) as gènes (that is, Genoa in French.) In English pronunciation, this term was transformed into 'jeans'. The first written record of the word [dates back to](#) 1567. The [spread](#) of jeans increased greatly with textile industrialisation in the 18th and 19th centuries. In the 19th century, this [garment](#) arrived in America [through](#) immigration and transatlantic [trade](#). Language

Gossip: The Social Glue Il pettegolezzo non è certo un'abitudine dei giorni nostri: ce lo dimostra l'origine della parola 'gossip'. Molly Malcolm, Graziella Del Ciuco

MR. LEVI STRAUSS

A German-born American [fabric](#) merchant and entrepreneur named Levi Strauss immediately understood the potential of this almost indestructible [garment](#). It seemed perfect for [gold prospectors](#), miners, railway workers, and cowboys. The idea of adding the famous [copper](#) rivets to [strengthen](#) points of stress and [wear](#), such as the pockets, came from Jacob Davis, an American [tailor](#) of [Latvian](#) origin. However, he did not have the sixty-eight dollars needed to register the patent, so he contacted Levi Strauss, who supplied the [fabric](#). They became partners and in 1873 they [filed](#) the patent together.

HOW DO YOU SAY...?

A intuito. By the seat of your pants.

BLUE JEANS

The [fabric](#) made by the Genoese was probably not the typical blue of modern jeans. It was mostly a natural [hue](#), that is, brownish, beige, or other [rough](#) tones that were resistant to [dirt](#). The blue colour we associate with jeans today arrived later, in the 19th century, with American industrial production and the use of indigo [dye](#), which was relatively cheap, [long-lasting](#) and easy to find. Most importantly, it was very effective at hiding [dirt](#).

YOUTH ICON

Until World War Two, jeans were still only a [humble](#) work uniform, and no one could imagine their future fame. It was only in the 1950s that they conquered young people and then the world. The decisive moment came [through](#) American cinema: when Marlon Brando and James Dean wore them in *The Wild One* and *Rebel Without a Cause*, respectively, jeans immediately became popular with youth culture.

EGALITARIAN GARMENT

From there, it was a short step to becoming a symbol of counterculture and rebellion among teenagers in the 1960s. Jeans turned into a kind of uniform that expressed rejection of conventions and formal clothing, based on a simple and powerful egalitarian idea: a [garment](#) equally worn by men and women, by the rich and the poor. And soon this symbol of Western culture would [break down geographical barriers](#) and become the most wide[spread](#) item of clothing in the world.

Glossary

- **trade** = commercio
- **dye** = tinta, colorante
- **humble** = umile
- **break down geographical barriers** = abbattere barriere
- **sails** = vele
- **strengthen** = rafforzare
- **hue** = tonalità
- **rough** = grezzi
- **fabric** = tessuto, stoffa
- **cotton** = cotone
- **spread** = diffusione
- **gold prospectors** = cercatori d'oro
- **long-lasting** = resistente
- **goods** = merci
- **therefore** = quindi
- **copper** = rame
- **wear** = usura
- **tailor** = sarto
- **Latvian** = lettone
- **filed** = depositare un brevetto
- **dirt** = sporco
- **sailors** = marinai
- **garment** = capo d'abbigliamento
- **dates back to** = risalire a